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Instability in Post-Divorce Residence Arrangements and Child Difficulties

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ABSTRACT

Objective: This study examines the instability in post-divorce child residence arrangements over a 10-year period and its impact on children's socioemotional difficulties.**Background:** The increase in shared residence arrangements (joint physical custody) has led to renewed interest in understanding how children fare in different post-divorce residence arrangements. These arrangements may, however, change as circumstances likely change after divorce, potentially affecting children's well-being.**Method:** Data from the “New Families in the Netherlands” survey covering three waves over 10 years after union dissolution were used. The sample included parents who divorced or separated from cohabitation in 2010. We used multiple linear regression analyses to estimate the association between instability in child residence and parent-reported socioemotional difficulties of children aged 4–17 years.**Results:** Instability in child residence arrangements was not uncommon, with nearly one-third of parents reporting change within 10 years. Sole mother residence was the most common and stable arrangement, while shared residence showed the highest instability. Instability was associated with increased child difficulties. Sole-to-sole residence changes had the strongest impact, while stable shared residence was associated with the least child difficulties.**Conclusion:** The study highlights the prevalence of instability in post-divorce residence arrangements and its negative impact on children's well-being. Our study nuances previous findings on the benefits of shared residence by showing that it is especially stable shared residence that benefits children.

1 | Introduction

Shifts toward more egalitarian gender roles and legal reforms promoting joint physical custody after divorce or separation have contributed to the rise in joint physical custody in recent decades (Kitterød and Wiik 2017; Meyer et al. 2022; Poortman and van Gaalen 2017). This increase has sparked renewed interest

in how children fare in different post-divorce child residence arrangements—another commonly used term for physical custody, which we will use hereafter—including shared residence (i.e., joint physical custody), sole mother residence (i.e., mother physical custody), and sole father residence (i.e., father physical custody). Whereas past research examined the link between child well-being and nonresident father involvement (Adamsons

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and Johnson 2013), recent research has focused on comparing sole residence with shared residence in which children spend about an equal amount of time in each parental home. Studies have so far shown that children in shared residence arrangements generally fare better than children in sole mother- or sole father residence, be it that effect sizes are small and that strict causal interpretations cannot be made due to the cross-sectional designs of these studies (Steinbach 2019).

Most research relates post-divorce residence arrangements to child outcomes at one moment in time (Berman and Daneback 2022; Steinbach 2019). Residence arrangements are, however, not set in stone, and originally agreed upon arrangements may change as circumstances likely change after a divorce, such as finding a new partner, a new house, or a new job. Shared residence arrangements, in particular, may be unstable because of the high interdependencies between partners and the coordination and cooperation it takes to maintain such an arrangement in the longer run (McIntosh et al. 2010; Poortman and van Gaalen 2017). Although the period over which changes have been tracked is often limited to about 3 years (for an exception, see Kitterød and Wiik 2017), the sparse evidence mostly shows that shared residence is less stable than sole mother residence. Previous research indicates that percentages of instability range from 3% to 10% for mother residence and from 10% to 60% for shared residence—with percentages ranging from 3% to 29% for the small (and perhaps selective) group with father residence arrangements (Berger et al. 2008; Kitterød and Wiik 2017; Poortman and van Gaalen 2017; Smyth et al. 2008). Furthermore, changes in residence are mostly in the direction of mother residence (Kitterød and Wiik 2017; Poortman and van Gaalen 2017; Smyth et al. 2008; for an exception, see Berger et al. 2008)—a phenomenon also called “maternal drift” (Berger et al. 2008).

Little is known about how stable residence arrangements are in the longer run and whether instability in residence arrangements poses a risk to children and their adjustment to divorce. According to the “instability perspective” (Wu and Martinson 1993; Fomby and Cherlin 2007), changes in children's family situations cause stress, which in turn negatively affects them. In the context of post-divorce residence arrangements, others, however, have argued that changes may be a sign of flexibility: a change indicates that families are able to adjust their arrangements when new circumstances make such adjustments necessary (Meyer et al. 2017). A non-causal argument is that parents who change their arrangements are a selective group, often negatively selected on characteristics associated with lower child well-being, such as high levels of parental conflict (Poortman and van Gaalen 2017). Although some studies have focused on stability in family structures (e.g., divorce, remarriage; see review by Cavanagh and Fomby 2019), there is, to our knowledge, no study that has examined how instability in post-divorce residence arrangements is related to child well-being.

In this study, we describe the extent of instability in children's post-divorce residence arrangements and examine how this instability is related to children's socioemotional difficulties. The extent to which children experience socioemotional difficulties is often used as a measure of child well-being and

considered indicative of their adjustment to divorce (Goodman and Goodman 2009). Residence arrangements relate to with whom the child lives most of the time after divorce or separation and include sole mother residence, sole father residence, and shared residence. We contribute to the literature by tracking changes in child residence over a longer period of time than previous work, that is, 10 years after divorce or separation. We not only examine whether and how often the main residence of the child changed, but also which type of changes (e.g., from mother to shared residence or from father to mother residence) are the most frequent. We furthermore extend previous work by examining the relationship with the extent to which the child experiences socioemotional difficulties. We examine how experiencing a change in residence arrangements and the number and type of changes are associated with children's socioemotional difficulties. All analyses control for a wide range of child and parent characteristics, such as parents' socioeconomic status and the amount of parental conflict, to account for any selectivity associated with changing child residence arrangements.

We use longitudinal and rich data from the Netherlands: the first wave (2012/2013), second wave (2015/2016) and third wave (2020) of the “New Families in the Netherlands” survey, consisting of a large sample of parents who divorced or separated from a cohabiting union in 2010 (NFN; Poortman et al. 2014, 2018, 2021). Besides repeated measures of the (focal) child's socioemotional difficulties in all three waves, data include half-yearly information on the residence arrangement of the child upon union dissolution up to 10 years afterwards. In the Netherlands, children most often live with their mother after union dissolution, but shared residence has become more prevalent in recent years (Poortman and van Gaalen 2017). Although shared residence is less common than in Nordic countries (e.g., Sweden), the Netherlands is an upper mid-tier country, with rates quite similar to Belgium. The country introduced extensive legislation promoting shared parenting after divorce—of which shared residence is the prime example—in 2009, so just before the parents in the NFN sample divorced or separated. NFN is thus particularly suitable for our research purposes, as the data include a relatively large number of parents with shared residence arrangements.

2 | Theoretical Background

2.1 | Changes in Child Residence and Child Difficulties

The instability perspective states that family instability lowers children's well-being (Wu and Martinson 1993). Family instability is defined as a change in a child's family structure and can refer to divorce and remarriage, but also to changes in post-divorce residence arrangements. Any change in children's family situation may in itself lead to stress. The reason is that these changes require adjustment to a new family situation, which is demanding and stressful in itself, and often involve various stressors, such as changes in access to parental resources (e.g., support, financial resources) or residential moves (Magnuson and Berger 2009; Cavanagh and Fomby 2019; Fomby and Sennott 2013; Fowler et al. 2015). Such negative effects may cumulate with each change, suggesting that multiple

transitions are particularly harmful for children (Cavanagh and Huston 2006; Fomby and Cherlin 2007).

In the context of changing residence arrangements, children have to adjust to a situation in which they spend more time in one parent's home at the expense of spending less time in the other parent's home. Although children may gain resources when it comes to the parent with whom they reside more often, the instability perspective views any change as such as stressful (Cavanagh and Fomby 2019). Furthermore, these gains may be outweighed by feelings of loss due to spending less time with the other parent and receiving less of this parent's resources (Poortman 2018). Children also have to get used to other rules and routines in the other parent's home and may experience instability in parenting styles (Lee and McLanahan 2015). In cases where parent(s) are repartnered, children have to deal with spending less time with the stepparent (and perhaps stepsiblings) with whom they no longer live (full time) in the household and/or have to get used to spending more time with stepfamily members in the other household. Given the ambiguous nature of stepfamily relationships (Cherlin 1978), these adjustments may be stressful. Children might also experience difficulties because a change in residence arrangements typically implies a residential move—be it less clearcut in the context of moving in or out of a shared residence arrangement. Moving may be stressful for children (e.g., Jelleymann and Spencer 2008; Scanlon and Devine 2001) and particularly so when they move over longer distances. In that case, children often move to a different neighborhood or change schools, which requires greater adjustments and may imply a weakening of children's existing friendships—with possibly adverse effects on children's well-being (Cavanagh and Fomby 2019; Poortman 2021).

Although the instability perspective predicts more socioemotional difficulties for children in case post-divorce residence arrangements (more often) change, other arguments suggest that the negative impact on children should be interpreted more cautiously. Residence arrangements may be changed in response to changing circumstances and thus reflect a family's flexibility in accommodating to new situations (Meyer et al. 2017). Particularly a high degree of responsiveness to the needs of the child is considered important. For shared residence arrangements, it has, for instance, been argued that changes may occur because older children, in particular, may no longer want to move between two homes, or because shared residence can be too demanding for children, especially very young ones (Fehlberg et al. 2011; Poortman and van Gaalen 2017; Steinbach 2019). In these instances, children may fare better after changing residence arrangements. This may also be the case, though perhaps less common, when a change in residence provides an escape from a difficult home situation (e.g., domestic violence). So far, there are no large-scale quantitative studies to substantiate the implication that instability in child residence arrangements may have less harmful or even positive effects on child well-being in these situations. Given that likely not all changes in residence arrangements are driven by child-related reasons (Poortman and van Gaalen 2017) and that research on stability in family structures more generally shows that, overall, family instability results in a lower child well-being (e.g., Cavanagh 2008; Cavanagh and Fomby 2019; Fomby and Cherlin 2007; Osborne and McLanahan 2007), we hypothesize that:

H1. *A change in the residence arrangement of the child is associated with more socioemotional difficulties of the child.*

H2. *The more changes in the residence arrangements of the child, the greater the socioemotional difficulties of the child.*

For reasons addressed above, we no longer address arguments about flexibility in responding to a child's needs and wants in the following and generally assume that instability in child residence arrangements is associated with an increase in child difficulties.

2.2 | Type of Change in Child Residence and Child Difficulties

Also, the type of change matters, with some changes being more disadvantageous for children than others (Johnston et al. 2020; Lee and McLanahan 2015; Magnuson and Berger 2009). Though all types of family change are disruptive and require adjustment, the extent to which children lose access to parental resources or experience stressful changes induced by family instability depends on the type of change (Lee and McLanahan 2015; Mitchell et al. 2015). An example of how the impact varies depending on the type of change is that divorce often reduces access to parental resources—typically the father's, given the prevalence of sole mother residence—whereas repartnering may increase access to resources, particularly those of the stepparent (Mitchell et al. 2015).

Regarding child residence arrangements, a shift from sole to sole residence (be it from mother residence to father residence or from father to mother residence) may be more consequential than a change from shared residence to sole residence or vice versa—as compared with a stable unchanged situation. The instability perspective regards all these changes as disadvantageous for children, yet changes are likely more profound in the former case than in the latter case. Although it is difficult to predict how gains and losses in parental resources compare between these two scenarios, other stressors are likely to be greater in the case of a sole-to-sole residence change. Children at least experience some continuation in their living situation with one of the parents in case sole residence is changed to shared residence or vice versa. Children's experience is more discontinuous when they change from living (mostly) full-time with one parent to living full-time with the other parent. Such a change asks for children's greater adjustment in terms of getting used to the rules, practices, and rituals in the other parent's house and this parent's parenting style (Lee and McLanahan 2015). Studies furthermore show that the geographical distance between the parents' homes is greater in a situation of sole residence than when children are in a shared residence arrangement (Poortman 2021; Thomas et al. 2018; Walper et al. 2021). Chances are thus higher that children move to a new neighborhood (perhaps even to another town) and change schools, meaning that children have to build new friendships and need to get socially integrated via sports or club memberships.

While few differences in the extent of residential moves and levels of discontinuity are expected when comparing a change from sole to shared residence with a change from shared to

sole residence, children gain access to both parents' resources when transitioning from sole to shared residence. In contrast, children have less access to one of the parent's resources in the case of the reversed scenario and, besides, children may also feel that a shift from shared to sole residence marks the definite end of the original family unit. We therefore hypothesize that:

H3. *Compared to stable residence arrangements, changes in residence arrangements relate to more socioemotional difficulties of the child, with this positive association being the strongest in the case of a change from sole to sole residence and the weakest in the case of a change from sole to shared residence, with a change from shared to sole residence falling in between.*

Although caution is warranted given the small and likely selective group of children in father residence (e.g., when the mother is ill), we may speculate about differences within the stable and unstable categories, depending on the specific residence arrangement. Consistent with previous findings showing that children in shared residence fare better than children in sole residence, it can be expected that children in stable shared residence experience fewer difficulties than those in stable mother or stable father residence. Though it is unclear how specific stressors would vary, the levels of stress induced by instability itself may depend on the direction of the change. Transitions toward more common and normatively expected arrangements (e.g., mother or shared residence) may be less stressful than shifts toward less common and more atypical arrangements, such as father residence. Thus a change from mother to father residence may relate to more child difficulties than a shift from father to mother residence. Similarly, a change from shared to father residence may relate to more child difficulties than a change from shared to mother residence. In addition, a change from mother to shared residence may be more strongly associated with child difficulties than a change from father to shared residence.

2.3 | Selection Into Change in Residence Arrangements

When analyzing the association between family instability and the child's socioemotional difficulties, it is important to be aware of non-causal explanations because those who experience instability may be selective on characteristics (e.g., socioeconomic characteristics, like education) that are also associated with child well-being (Cavanagh and Fomby 2019). When it comes to unstable residence arrangements, the few existing studies on the correlates of such instability focus on changes that involve shared residence arrangements (i.e., shared-to-sole residence changes or sole-to-shared residence changes) rather than on mother–father residence changes (e.g., Claessens and Mortelmans 2021; Poortman and van Gaalen 2017). This is not surprising, given the often low number of individuals with a father residence arrangement. There are also related studies that look at the correlates of trajectories of change in (nonresident) father-child contact following divorce (Baude et al. 2023; Cheadle et al. 2010). Most of these studies (for an exception, see Poortman and van Gaalen 2017) conflate instability (i.e., likelihood of transitions) with having much contact with the father after divorce—be it in the form of shared residence or

high father-child contact levels (i.e., being in certain states, e.g., a situation of little contact versus that of high contact levels). Keeping these cautionary notes in mind, findings suggest that (a change to) shared residence or more contact with the father in general is more likely in high SES families, low conflict families, and when parents live geographically close to each other (Baude et al. 2023; Cheadle et al. 2010; Claessens and Mortelmans 2021)—characteristics that are also known to be associated with a higher child well-being.

Regarding the probability of instability, a change from shared to sole residence versus stable shared residence is more likely among lower educated parents, high conflict divorces, when parents live far apart, and when children had many social-psychological problems prior to divorce or separation (Poortman and van Gaalen 2017). These characteristics are also likely associated with lower levels of child well-being. Some studies also find associations with repartnering of the mother and/or father (Claessens and Mortelmans 2021; Poortman and van Gaalen 2017), but findings are mixed and the same holds for the impact of parental repartnering on child outcomes (Hadfield et al. 2018). Overall, (stable) shared residence is thus found to be positively selected, that is, on characteristics that also improve child well-being, leading to a spurious positive association between (stable) shared residence and child well-being. The reverse is true for a change from shared to sole residence, which has been shown to be an example of negative selection. To reduce selectivity issues, we control for many child and parental characteristics, such as parental education, parental conflict, prior problems of the child, and travel distance between parents.

3 | Method

3.1 | Data

We use three waves of the New Families in the Netherlands (NFN) survey (Poortman et al. 2014, 2018, 2021; Poortman and Van Gaalen 2019a, 2019b). The first wave was held in 2012–2013. The sampling was done by Statistics Netherlands (CBS) using Dutch register data. A random sample was taken from the population of heterosexual parents with minor children who officially divorced or separated from cohabitation in 2010. Both parents from a former household were asked to participate in an online survey, with the final reminder also including a paper-and-pencil questionnaire. The response rate for Wave 1 was 39% among persons and 58% among former households, with a total of 4481 parents participating.

Respondents who gave permission to be recontacted at the time of Wave 1 were invited to participate in Wave 2 in 2015 (i.e., 5 years after divorce/separation). The response rate was 63% among persons and 69% among former households ($N = 2544$). In addition, a refreshment sample from the same population as in Wave 1 was approached. The response rate for this sample was 32% on the person level and 52% on the household level ($N = 920$). The total sample in Wave 2 adds up to 3464 responding parents.

The third wave, which took place in 2020 during the corona pandemic, occurred 10 years after divorce or separation.

Respondents who either participated in only Wave 1 or in both previous waves as well as respondents from the refreshment sample were approached, provided that they had given permission to do so. The response rate of Wave 3 was 68% among persons and 72% among households, with a total sample of 3056 parents. The most consistent patterns of underrepresentation for all three waves were that former cohabiters, men, younger people, people of non-Western descent, and people with low incomes or on welfare were less likely to participate. Having a higher socioeconomic status (education, employment) was most predictive of participating again in Wave 2 and Wave 3. Also, women, older people, and respondents with high life satisfaction (in case of Wave 2) and with a new partner (Wave 3) were more likely to participate in subsequent wave(s). More information about selectivity in the NFN data can be found in the codebooks of Waves 1, 2, and 3 (Poortman et al. 2014, 2018, 2021).

It is important to note that parents, not children, participated in NFN. Information about children was thus reported by the parents. In Wave 1, one focal child was selected. If at least one of the children was 10 years old or older at Wave 1, parents reported about the youngest child of 10 years or older. If all children were younger than 10, parents reported about their oldest child. In Wave 2 and Wave 3, parents answered questions about the same child as in Wave 1. Because Wave 2 was about 3 years later than Wave 1, the age for selecting the focal child was 13 years for parents in the refreshment sample.

The total sample with which we started consisted of 5401 parents, including 4481 parents who participated in Wave 1 and 920 parents from the refreshment sample. Several selections were made on the person level for this study (see [Supporting Information: Table A1](#) for an overview of all the selection steps). First, we excluded respondents who only participated in Wave 1 ($n = 1352$) and those who only participated in Wave 1 and Wave 3 ($n = 602$). The reason is that changes in the residence of the child were asked from Wave 2 onwards (i.e., tracking change since union dissolution until the time of Wave 2) and that only changes since the previous wave (i.e., Wave 2) were asked for in Wave 3. Our data thus include (1) parents who participated in Waves 1 and 2 (so followed up to 5 years after divorce/separation), (2) parents from the refreshment sample who only participated in Wave 2 (also followed up to 5 years), and (3) parents who participated in all three waves or parents from the refreshment sample who participated in both Waves 2 and 3 (so followed up to 10 years). These groups are shown in [Supporting Information: Table A1](#). Second, we excluded everyone who indicated that they had already split up before 2008 ($n = 238$), because changes in the residence arrangements of the focal child were tracked since 2009, resulting in approximately the same time span of 10 years after divorce/separation in 2020 for all respondents. Third, if both ex-partners of the original household participated, which was the case for 29% of former households, we randomly selected one parent, so that information on the child is included only once in our sample (excluded $n = 516$). As shown in [Supporting Information: Table A2](#), ex-partners generally reported consistent information on changes in child residence arrangements. Eventually, the sample consists of 2693 parents and this total is used for the descriptive analyses about changes in the residence arrangement of the focal child.

To analyze the associations with child difficulties, we utilized the repeated measures of child well-being across waves by restructuring the data into a person-period file (Allison 1984), creating separate records for each wave. The total number of records is 7273, and also on the record level we lose cases, occasionally resulting in complete respondent-level exclusion. First, the used measure for the dependent variable (i.e., child's socioemotional difficulties) only relates to children between 4 and 17 years old (see below). This means that parents with young children in the first wave (below age 4) or parents with older children in later waves (older than 17) were not or were no longer included in the data. This results in excluding 2496 records and 171 parents. Second, records with missing values on all other independent variables were deleted, resulting in the exclusion of 208 records and 98 parents. The final sample consists of 2424 respondents and 4569 records (see flow chart, [Supporting Information: Table A1](#), which also shows the distribution of respondents having one, two, or three observations). As explained, this sample includes both formerly married and formerly cohabiting parents. With nearly half of children in the Netherlands now born to unmarried couples (Statistics Netherlands 2023), cohabitation has become commonplace, with minimal differences between marriage and cohabitation.

To assess potential bias due to attrition and exclusion, we compared key demographics between respondents who dropped out and those in the final analytical sample (see [Supporting Information: Table A3](#)). Participants in the research sample were slightly younger, more often women, and higher educated. No significant differences were found in marital status before separation or the number of children. These results indicate some selectivity, which should be kept in mind when interpreting the findings.

3.2 | Measures of Central Variables

Child well-being was measured using the parent report version of the "Strength and Difficulties Questionnaire" (SDQ) (Goodman 1997), which was asked in all three waves. The SDQ, applicable to children aged 4–17 years, assesses the social, emotional, and behavioral difficulties of the child and consists of 25 different questions relating to five subscales, with high scores indicating more socioemotional difficulties (Goodman 1997). Parents had to mark whether each of the 25 items related to the behavior of the focal child were (0) not true, (1) somewhat true or (2) certainly true. Examples of items are "Many worries, often seems worried," "Easily distracted, concentration wanders," "Often lies or cheats." We reversed some items so that for all items a high score means more child difficulties. We calculated the "Total Difficulties Score" using the script on the SDQ website (www.sdqinfo.org) and constructed a variable *child difficulties* by adding up all items referring to four (of the five) subscales: emotional symptoms, hyperactivity-inattention difficulties, conduct difficulties, and peer relationship difficulties. The fifth subscale, prosocial behavior, is not included in this total score because it reflects positive behavior rather than difficulties, following the SDQ guidelines. The internal consistency of the Total Difficulties Score was good across all three waves (Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.84$ in Wave 1, 0.85 in Wave 2, and 0.81 in Wave 3). The

Total Difficulties Score can range from 0 to 40. As mentioned above, we transformed the data into a person-period file with separate records for each wave, as child difficulties were assessed at each wave. This makes the dependent variable time-varying, accounting for changes in child well-being over time.

The central independent variables are threefold. First, we measured whether *a change in the child's residence arrangement* happened in the years after separation (1 = yes, 0 = no). We used a question, first asked in Wave 2 (so 5 years after divorce/separation in 2010), where all respondents had to fill in a calendar in which they were asked with whom the focal child lived most of the time during the past 5 years per period of 6 months from the moment of separation. Respondents could choose between "mother residence," "father residence," "with both (approximately) equal" (so, shared residence) or "other residence." Since the meaning of "other residence" can vary greatly, we decided to code this response as missing. The completed calendar resulted in a detailed overview of the residence of the child from 2010 until 2015 for every half year. Some respondents separated in 2009, for these respondents the calendar started in 2009. The same question was asked again in Wave 3, but then for the period 2015 until 2020 and we used this to expand the detailed overview to 2020. In Wave 3, parents could also indicate that their child had started to live independently. If this was the case and the child was below the age of 18, the residence of the child was coded missing ($n = 4$ respondents). Because the data were transformed into a person-period file, we were able to identify for each wave (i.e., record) whether a change in the child's residence arrangement had occurred, making this independent variable time-varying.

The second central independent variable is a categorical time-varying variable measuring the *number of changes*, thus how many times the residence of the child changed since separation. Because only a few parents changed their child's residence three times or more ($n = 85$), all parents who changed the residence more than three times were given a maximum of 3. This results in a variable with four categories: (0) no change, (1) one change, (2) two changes, and (3) three or more changes in child residence arrangements.

The third independent variable is the *type of change in residence arrangements*, which is also time-varying. We constructed two variants, the first one being a variable with four categories: (1) stable residence, (2) a change from shared to sole residence, (3) a change from sole to shared residence, and (4) a change from sole to sole residence. Though our hypotheses focus more broadly on these four categories, we also analyze more specific changes. We constructed a variable with nine different types of changes in residence arrangements, of which three are stable residence arrangements: (1) mother residence, (2) father residence, and (3) shared residence. Once parents changed the residence of the focal child, there were several types of changes: (4) mother to shared residence, (5) mother to father residence, (6) father to shared residence, (7) father to mother residence, (8) shared to mother residence, and (9) shared to father residence. If multiple changes in residence occurred within one observation period (i.e., within the same

record), we could only include the most recent change in the analyses.

3.3 | Measures of Control Variables

As discussed in the theory section on selection, it is crucial to control for specific child and parental characteristics. We control for a host of characteristics that are associated with instability and may also influence child socioemotional difficulties. Some of these variables are time-varying, because they have been asked in each wave, specifically *duration since separation* (ranging from 0 to 12 years), *child's age* (between 4 and 17 years old, centered around the mean), *distance between ex-partners* (traveling time between parents' houses in minutes with a maximum set at 240 min), *repartnering of parents* (1 = yes, 0 = no), and whether the *child has step-siblings* (1 = yes, 0 = no) and/or *half-siblings* (1 = yes, 0 = no). Repartnering means that parents lived together with a new partner (be it married or cohabiting). We also controlled for *parental conflict*, indicating how often the respondent had conflicts or tensions with the ex-partner (0 = never to 3 = very often). The amount of conflict was measured at various moments, pre-separation (retrospectively asked for in Wave 1) but also after separation (at the time of the survey). To construct a time-varying variable, we measured parental conflict in the previous wave or before separation, ensuring parental conflict is measured prior to the moment of the survey asking about child difficulties. Other control variables are constant over time: *gender of the child* (0 = girl, 1 = boy), *gender of the responding parent* (0 = man, 1 = woman), *marital status before separation* (1 = married, 0 = cohabiting), *the number of children with the ex-partner*, *physical health problems*, *behavioral problems and psychosocial problems of the child before separation* (each coded 1 = yes, 0 = no), *mother's and father's highest level of education* (1 = less than primary education to 10 = postgraduate), and *the number of parental pre-separation problems* (counting the number of the following problems the respondent or the ex-partner had (1 = yes): "serious physical illness or handicap," "serious psychological problems," "violence, drug or alcohol addiction" and/or "contact with police" (excluding traffic offenses)). The descriptive statistics of the dependent variable and the control variables can be found in Table 1. The changes in the child's residence are discussed in detail in Section 4.

3.4 | Analytical Strategy

For the analyses describing changes in the focal child's residence arrangement, we started from the original child residence arrangement at the time of divorce or separation and examined whether and how often this original arrangement changed (i.e., any change and the number of changes). This analysis pertained to the person level ($N = 2693$). Because residence arrangements may change more than once, we furthermore analyzed the type of changes that were made on the level of changes. A total of $N = 1265$ changes in residence arrangements were observed. The analyses examining the role of instability in child residence arrangements for child difficulties were conducted using the person-period file (see also

TABLE 1 | Descriptive statistics of the dependent and control variables.

	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>	<i>Range</i>
Dependent variable			
Child socioemotional difficulties Wave 1 ^a	7.21	5.67	0–31
Child socioemotional difficulties Wave 2 ^a	7.05	5.80	0–40
Child socioemotional difficulties Wave 3 ^a	7.48	5.69	0–30
Control variables			
Duration since separation	5.15	2.80	0–12
Child characteristics			
Child's age	11.91	3.41	4–17
Child is boy	0.39		0–1
Child behavioral problems before separation	0.18		0–1
Child physical problems before separation	0.15		0–1
Child social problems before separation	0.16		0–1
Parent characteristics			
Distance between ex-partners (in minutes)	21.30	31.78	0–240
Repartnering mother	0.45		0–1
Repartnering father	0.53		0–1
Having step siblings	0.35		0–1
Having half siblings	0.09		0–1
Parental conflict	1.42	1.07	0–3
Number of children with ex-partner	1.86	0.76	1–6
Mother's education	6.50	1.93	1–10
Father's education	6.35	2.15	1–10
Respondent is woman	0.62		0–1
Parental pre-separation problems	0.52	0.80	0–4
Married before separation	0.69		0–1
<i>N</i> of respondents	2424		
<i>N</i> of observations	4569		

^aMeasured by Strength and Difficulties Questionnaire (Goodman 1997): Total Difficulties Score.

Source: All three waves of New Families in the Netherlands.

above), which contains separate records for each survey wave in which information on the child's well-being was available. The person-period file spans from the first survey wave with information on the child's well-being—either Wave 1

(2012/2013) or Wave 2 (2015/2016)—to the last wave in which the respondent still participated and the child was between 4 and 17 years old, as socioemotional difficulties were only measured for children within this age range. This final wave could be either Wave 2 (2015/2016) or Wave 3 (2020).

Some parents changed residence arrangements more than once between waves, and in this case, the most recent change was chosen when analyzing the type of changes. In addition to this survey wave-based person-period file, we also explored an alternative setup using a person-period file with half-year intervals, based on the availability of child residence information. As both approaches produced similar results, we present findings based on the survey wave person-period file for reasons of interpretability and clarity. Based on this file, we estimated linear regression analyses with child socioemotional difficulties as the dependent variable and the variables capturing instability of residence arrangements as the central independent variables. We estimated two models for each measure of instability: (1) a baseline model without control variables, and (2) a model including all control variables to account for selectivity. In all models, the standard errors are clustered on the respondent level to account for within-respondent dependence. Clustering at the (former) household level was unnecessary, as one parent was randomly selected for the analysis. Supplementary analyses, which included both parents and accounted for clustering at the individual and household levels, yielded similar results.

4 | Results

Table 2 shows the distribution of the original child's residence at the time of separation, and whether and how often this original residence was changed after 2, 5, and 10 years. Mother residence was the most common arrangement right after divorce or separation ($N=1667$ of the 2684 parents, 62%), followed by shared residence (32%) and father residence (6%), respectively. Two years after separation, 14% of the parents reported change in child residence ($N=373$, i.e., 14% of 2684 parents). The majority of these parents changed the residence of their child only once in these 2 years (84%). The results in Table 2 show that 5 years after separation, the percentage of parents who changed their child's residence increased to one-fourth ($N=664$, i.e., 25% of 2693). Ten years after separation, almost one-third of the parents reported instability in their child's residence ($N=841$, i.e., 31% of 2693 parents). Even 10 years after separation, the majority of these parents had changed the residence of their child only once (68%).

When looking at instability by the original residence arrangement, mother residence appeared to be the most stable. Within 10 years after separation, 79% of parents who originally opted for mother residence did not change this arrangement. These percentages were lower for father residence (52% was stable) and shared residence (52%). Note though that father residence was rare and might be a selective group.

Overall, the results show that mother residence was the most stable arrangement, while nearly half of the parents with a shared residence arrangement changed this arrangement within 10 years after separation. Though shared residence was the least

TABLE 2 | Descriptive results regarding change in original residence at separation and the number of changes (given change) 2, 5, and 10 years after separation: *N* and row percentages.

Original residence	No change	Any change	Total	1 change	>1 change	Total (given change)
Two years after separation						
Mother residence	1538	129	1667	103	26	129
	92.3%	7.7%		79.8%	20.2%	
Father residence	100	50	150	40	10	50
	66.7%	33.3%		80.0%	20.0%	
Shared residence	673	194	867	170	24	194
	77.6%	22.4%		87.6%	12.4%	
Total	2311	373	2,684 ^a	313	60	373
	86.1%	13.9%		83.9%	16.1%	
Five years after separation						
Mother residence	1398	277	1675	187	90	277
	83.5%	16.5%		67.5%	32.5%	
Father residence	84	67	151	43	24	67
	55.6%	44.4%		64.2%	35.8%	
Shared residence	547	320	867	257	63	320
	63.1%	36.9%		80.3%	19.7%	
Total	2029	664	2693	487	177	664
	75.3%	24.7%		73.3%	26.7%	
Ten years after separation						
Mother residence	1322	353	1675	213	140	353
	78.9%	21.1%		60.3%	39.7%	
Father residence	79	72	151	41	31	72
	52.3%	47.7%		56.9%	43.2%	
Shared residence	451	416	867	316	100	416
	52.0%	48.0%		76.0%	24.0%	
Total	1852	841	2693	570	271	841
	68.8%	31.2%		67.8%	32.2%	

^aThe total *N* is slightly lower 2 years after separation than 5 and 10 years after separation because, after 2 years after separation, not everyone had started filling out the semi-annual calendar.

stable arrangement 10 years later, note that this arrangement was more often changed only once compared with the other ones (76% compared with 57% for father residence and 60% for mother residence). Although not shown in Table 2 because of low numbers, three or more changes were relatively uncommon; little over 10% of the parents who changed their child's residence did so three times or more and about 20% changed their child's residence twice.

Table 2 does not show which changes were exactly made. Table 3 therefore displays details about all the changes in child residence arrangements that were made in the observed period. In total, 1265 changes were made by 841 parents. Of these changes,

TABLE 3 | Descriptive results regarding the type of change in child residence, given change (*N* = 1265 changes).

Type of change	<i>N</i>	%
Mother—Shared residence	290	22.9%
Mother—Father residence	181	14.3%
Father—Shared residence	87	6.9%
Father—Mother residence	105	8.3%
Shared—Mother residence	406	32.1%
Shared—Father residence	196	15.5%

a shift from shared residence to mother residence was the most common (32%). In contrast, a change from shared residence to father residence was half as frequent (16%). Children who initially lived with their mother and experienced a change in their main residence were more likely to change to shared residence than to father residence. In fact, the change from mother to shared residence was the second most common change (23%). Changes involving a move from father to shared residence or father to mother residence were rare, as father residence was the least common arrangement at the time of divorce or separation. Among children initially living with their father, residence changes more often involved a move to their mother (8% of all changes) than to shared residence (7%). Comparing the more common arrangements of mother residence and shared residence, children moved less frequently to their fathers than to their mothers (16% vs. 32% in case of a change in shared residence) or to shared residence (14% vs. 23% in case of a change in mother residence).

As shown in Table 3, most changes in child residence involved a move to mother residence ($105 + 406/1265 = 40\%$), compared with moves to shared residence ($290 + 87/1265 = 30\%$) or father residence ($181 + 196/1265 = 30\%$), supporting the drift to mother residence.

4.1 | Instability in Child Residence and Child Difficulties

The results of the linear regression analyses for the association between a change (yes/no) in the residence of the child and child difficulties are shown in Table 4. In Model 1, without control variables, the estimate for a change in child residence was positive ($b = 1.01, p < 0.01$), indicating that instability as such was associated with more socioemotional difficulties of the child. Once the control variables were added (Model 2), the estimate slightly decreased and remained statistically significant: A change in child residence resulted in a 0.89 increase in child difficulties, which is in line with our first hypothesis. Note that this is a small effect size (Cohen's $d = 0.16 (=0.89/5.73 (=SD(Y)))$).

Regarding the number of changes, Model 1 generally shows that a greater number of changes in the residence of the child was associated with greater socioemotional difficulties of the child. Compared with children experiencing no change, children who changed their residence once had more child difficulties ($b = 0.86, p < 0.01$) and this difference was greater for those who changed residence two times ($b = 1.34, p < 0.05$). The estimates show that particularly the difference between children experiencing no change and those experiencing one or two changes was large. Once control variables were added, the estimates in Model 2 were somewhat smaller, but the pattern was the same.

In line with previous findings, older children had fewer socioemotional difficulties than younger children, and boys had more difficulties than girls. Pre-separation behavioral, physical, and social problems were all associated with higher levels of socioemotional difficulties in children after the separation. More parental problems before separation were also linked to greater child difficulties afterward. A greater number of siblings and a higher education of mother and father were associated with

fewer child difficulties. Moreover, mothers reported fewer socioemotional child difficulties than fathers. Child difficulties furthermore increased in cases where parents lived further apart and when parents had more conflict. Finally, the longer ago the separation, the more difficulties a child had, which is surprising. A reason may be that the last wave took place during the corona pandemic, a period in which children's well-being deteriorated significantly (Wade et al. 2020). The positive duration estimate may also be due to a lower age of the child at the time of separation at high durations: because children who turned 18 were no longer included in the sample (SDQ not measured), children who were younger at the time of separation were overrepresented among higher durations, which could explain the greater difficulties observed.

Table 5 shows the results for the association between the type of change in child residence and child difficulties. Using a less detailed measure of the type of change, Model 1 shows that children who changed from shared to sole residence (either sole father or sole mother residence; $b = 0.78, p < 0.05$) or from sole to sole residence ($b = 3.43, p < 0.01$) had more socioemotional difficulties than children experiencing no instability (thus, a lack of change).

When also analyzing other contrasts (only statistically significant contrasts shown by notes), children who changed from sole to sole residence had more difficulties than children changing from shared to sole residence or vice versa. Once all control variables were included (Model 2), we see that all estimates decreased in size, but those being statistically significant in Model 1 remained so. Overall, children who experienced no change had the fewest difficulties, whereas children who changed from sole to sole residence (father to mother residence or vice versa) experienced the most difficulties. Children who experienced changes involving shared residence fell in between. These results largely support our third hypothesis, although there is no convincing evidence of fewer child difficulties when changing from sole to shared residence rather than from shared to sole residence, given the lack of a statistically significant difference between these groups.

We also used a more detailed measure with nine categories, of which three refer to stable residence arrangements (mother, father, and shared residence) and six to changes in child residence arrangements. In both Models 1 and 2, the reference category is stable mother residence. Model 1 shows that, compared with children who continuously lived with their mother, children who lived in a stable shared residence had fewer socioemotional difficulties ($b = -1.97, p < .01$), whereas children who changed from mother to father residence ($b = 2.15, p < 0.01$) or from father to mother residence ($b = 3.72, p < 0.01$) had more difficulties. All other categories did not differ from stable mother residence. When analyzing other contrasts by changing the reference category (only statistically significant contrasts shown by notes), two groups stood out: (1) children in stable shared residence, and (2) children changing from sole to sole residence (be it mother-to-father residence or father-to-mother residence). Stable shared residence differed from all other types of residence (except for the change from father to shared residence), meaning that children in a stable shared residence arrangement had the fewest socioemotional difficulties compared with all the other types.

TABLE 4 | Linear regression of child difficulties on any change and number of changes in child residence.

	Change		Number of changes	
	Model 1	Model 2	Model 1	Model 2
	B (SE)	B (SE)	B (SE)	B (SE)
Change in child residence	1.01** (0.26)	0.89** (0.24)		
Number of changes (ref. no change)				
1 change			0.86** (0.28)	0.77** (0.25)
2 changes			1.34* (0.57)	1.14* (0.55)
3 or more changes			1.83 (1.04)	1.64 (1.00)
Age child (mean centered)		−0.16** (0.03)		−0.16** (0.03)
Child is boy		0.61** (0.20)		0.62** (0.20)
Pre-separation behavioral problems child		2.47** (0.31)		2.47** (0.31)
Pre-separation physical problems child		1.81** (0.32)		1.82** (0.32)
Pre-separation social problems child		2.14** (0.32)		2.14** (0.32)
Duration since separation		0.19** (0.04)		0.19** (0.04)
Number of children		−0.70** (0.14)		−0.69** (0.14)
Pre-separation problems parents		0.38** (0.14)		0.38** (0.14)
Education mother		−0.18** (0.06)		−0.18** (0.06)
Education father		−0.19** (0.05)		−0.19** (0.05)
Distance between ex-partners		0.01** (0.00)		0.01** (0.00)
Parental conflict		0.50** (0.08)		0.50** (0.08)
Repartnering mother		−0.11 (0.18)		−0.11 (0.18)
Repartnering father		0.24 (0.18)		0.24 (0.18)
Child having step siblings		−0.02 (0.19)		−0.02 (0.19)
Child having half siblings		0.31 (0.35)		0.32 (0.35)
Respondent is woman		−0.64** (0.21)		−0.64** (0.21)
Married before separation		0.32 (0.22)		0.33 (0.22)
R^2	0.01	0.16	0.01	0.16
N observations	4569	4569	4569	4569
N respondents	2424	2424	2424	2424

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$ (two-sided).

Source: All three waves of New Families in the Netherlands.

Thus, while our results using the less detailed change measure already indicated that stable residence arrangements were associated with the fewest child difficulties, the more detailed results suggest that it is specifically stable shared residence that is most advantageous for children. Once children changed from shared residence to mother or father residence, however, they did less well, as indicated by the statistically significant differences between these children and the children in stable shared residence.

On the other side of the spectrum, results show that children who experienced a change from father to mother residence or vice versa had the most socioemotional difficulties compared with the other categories. Children changing from father to mother residence

differed from most other residence categories (except for a change from mother to father residence), while children experiencing the reverse change (mother to father residence) also differed from most other categories (except for stable father residence, shared to father residence and father to mother changes). Some of these observed differences can be attributed to selectivity. When control variables were added (Model 2), differences became smaller and some were no longer statistically significant, particularly the differences with mother to father changes. Note though that the number of cases was limited for some of the change categories (see Table 3). The general pattern of two groups standing out (i.e., children in stable shared residence and sole to sole changes) remained evident in Model 2. As for the control variables, the findings in Table 5 mimic those in Table 4 and are therefore not shown in Table 5.

TABLE 5 | Linear regression of child difficulties on the type of change in child residence.

	Model 1	Model 2	Model 1	Model 2
	B (SE)	B (SE)	B (SE)	B (SE)
Type of change (ref. stable residence)				
Shared to sole residence	0.78 ^{*,a} (0.33)	0.63 ^{*,a} (0.30)		
Sole to shared residence	0.16 ^a (0.40)	0.48 ^a (0.38)		
Sole to sole residence	3.43 ^{**} (0.59)	2.54 ^{**} (0.57)		
Type of change (ref. stable mother residence)				
Stable father residence			0.72 ^{b,c} (0.73)	0.93 ^{b,c} (0.67)
Stable shared residence			-1.97 ^{**,c,d} (0.22)	-1.00 ^{**,c,d} (0.22)
Shared to mother residence			0.05 ^{b-d} (0.39)	0.19 ^{b,c} (0.34)
Shared to father residence			0.75 ^{b,c} (0.66)	0.91 ^{b,c} (0.62)
Mother to shared residence			-0.52 ^{b-d} (0.44)	0.12 ^{b,c} (0.42)
Mother to father residence			2.15 ^{**,b} (0.74)	1.63 ^{*,b} (0.74)
Father to shared residence			0.08 ^{b,c} (0.96)	0.32 ^c (0.96)
Father to mother residence			3.72 ^{**,b} (0.92)	3.22 ^{**,b} (0.83)
<i>R</i> ²	0.01	0.16	0.03	0.17
<i>N</i> observations	4569	4569	4569	4569
<i>N</i> respondents	2424	2424	2424	2424

Note: Model 2 includes the control variables. The estimates for control variables are not shown because these mimic the ones in Table 4.

^aDiffers significantly ($p < 0.05$) from sole to sole residence.

^bDiffers significantly ($p < 0.05$) from stable shared residence.

^cDiffers significantly ($p < 0.05$) from a change from father to mother residence.

^dDiffers significantly ($p < 0.05$) from a change from mother to father residence.

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$ (two-sided).

Source: All three waves of New Families in the Netherlands.

4.2 | Additional Analyses

We also explored whether the association between instability in child residence and child difficulties depended on the child's age and gender (see results in [Supporting Information: Tables A4 and A5](#)) as is often done in previous research (Cavanagh and Fomby 2019). The results indicate that the association between residential instability and child difficulties did not differ between younger and older children. Analyses focusing on the change per se as well as the number of changes revealed no significant age differences ([Supporting Information: Table A4, Model 1](#)). Similarly, analyses examining the type of residential change showed no significant differences between younger and older children ([Supporting Information: Table A5, Model 1](#)). In addition to the interaction with the child's current age, we also examined whether the child's age at the time of separation could be relevant. The results for the interaction between child residence and age at separation showed no differences between young and older children at the time of separation.

With regard to the child's gender, analyses did not show clear gender differences, suggesting minimal differences in the association between instability in child residence and child difficulties between boys and girls ([Supporting Information: Tables A4 and A5, Model 2](#)).

5 | Discussion

Post-divorce child residence arrangements are not set in stone and may, for instance, be changed if arrangements turn out to be unfeasible in practice or when circumstances change in the years following divorce or separation (e.g., repartnering, moving). So far, few studies have tracked changes in child residence arrangements and often over a limited period (e.g., Berger et al. 2008; Kitterød and Wiik 2017; Smyth et al. 2008). More importantly, studies have not examined the impact of instability in child residence on child well-being so far—even though prior work suggests that such instability is not rare and that family instability in general is disadvantageous for children (Cavanagh and Fomby 2019). This study aimed to fill these two gaps in the literature using longitudinal Dutch data.

Our study, first, showed that instability in child residence arrangements was not uncommon. Almost one-third of the parents reported that child residence arrangements had been changed within 10 years after divorce or separation. Residence arrangements were most often only changed once, but still nearly a third of the children whose residence arrangements changed experienced more than one change—some even three times or more. It is difficult to compare these numbers to those found in prior studies about instability in child residence (e.g., Berger et al. 2008; Kitterød and Wiik 2017; Smyth et al. 2008). These studies used different research designs, did not provide numbers about overall instability, but rather reported the percentages of change per original child residence type, and focused on changes over a more limited period of time, often 3 years since divorce. Nonetheless, our findings showed that instability steadily increased from 2 to 5 to 10 years after separation, suggesting that previous studies may have underestimated the extent of changes in child residence arrangements.

Second, mother residence was found to be the most common and most stable arrangement, and there appeared to be a “maternal drift” (Maccoby and Mnookin 1992; Berger et al. 2008), which is in line with previous research (e.g., Kitterød and Wiik 2017; Poortman and van Gaalen 2017; Smyth and Moloney 2008). Nearly half of the parents who opted for shared residence upon separation changed the child's residence within 10 years, compared with just one-fifth of those who initially chose mother residence. Changes in father residence were also relatively common, about 49%, which is higher than what previous research has shown (Berger et al. 2008; Kitterød and Wiik 2017; Poortman and van Gaalen 2017; Smyth et al. 2008). However, it is important to note that father residence was rare to begin with, also in earlier studies, suggesting that this might be a selective group. The likelihood of instability in shared residence arrangements was more than twice as high as in mother-residence arrangements, which is consistent with prior research (Berger et al. 2008; Kitterød and Wiik 2017; Poortman and van Gaalen 2017; Smyth et al. 2008). This may be attributed to the increased cooperation and coordination that shared residence demands from parents, as well as the arrangement's greater vulnerability to shifts in parents' family and work circumstances given the many parental interdependencies (McIntosh et al. 2010; Poortman and van Gaalen 2017). Child-related reasons may play a role as well, such as children no longer wanting to continuously alternate between parents' homes (Fehlberg et al. 2011; Steinbach 2019). Besides, mother residence appearing to be less difficult to sustain than other residence arrangements, it was also the most common arrangement at the time of separation (nearly two-thirds) and subsequent changes in child residence were most often in the direction of mother residence: about 40% of all changes were in the direction of children living most of the time with their mother compared with about 30% in the direction of either of the two other arrangements. Although the extent of this “maternal drift” was modest and shared residence was also quite often chosen at the time of divorce or separation (a third of cases), our findings, all in all, suggest that mothers continue to have a central role in caring for and raising children, despite changing gender roles and changing legislation stimulating a greater role of fathers after divorce in the Netherlands (Poortman and van Gaalen 2017).

Third, instability in child residence was associated with greater socioemotional difficulties of children. Children who experienced changes in their residence arrangement fared worse. The findings on the number of changes were somewhat less convincing in terms of statistical significance, but this is likely due to the small number of cases experiencing multiple changes. Our findings thus add to the existing body of research on family instability in general, showing that instability—referring to disruptions in a child's family structure, such as divorce, remarriage, but also changes in post-divorce residence arrangements—is often harmful to children (see review Cavanagh and Fomby 2019). Theoretically, the harmful impact of changes in child residence may be explained by the instability perspective, which has most often been used to explain the role of family instability in other respects (e.g., divorce, remarriage). Just as for any other type of family instability, the harmful impact of changes in a child's main residence may be due to elevated stress as these changes require adjusting to a new family situation, including different routines and rituals. Other stressors, such as having to move to another neighborhood, may further add to a child's stress levels

as has been shown by more general studies on the impact of moving on child well-being (Fomby and Sennott 2013; Fowler et al. 2015). Although some scholars have hinted at positive effects on child well-being by arguing that child residence changes may be a sign of flexibility, such as being responsive to children's needs (Meyer et al. 2017), our results do not support this view. However, it is important to note that not all children are negatively affected; some may even benefit from changes if they prefer living with one parent.

Fourth, the type of change mattered, with children in stable shared residence doing best and children changing from father to mother residence or vice versa doing worst. A sole-to-sole residence change might be problematic for children because such a change is most discontinuous and likely to be associated with moves over longer distances (Thomas et al. 2018; Walper et al. 2021). In contrast, children in stable shared residence had the fewest socioemotional difficulties, both compared with unstable arrangements and stable sole residence arrangements. These results corroborate findings from cross-sectional studies showing a positive association between shared residence and child well-being at one particular moment in time (Berman and Daneback 2022; Steinbach 2019), yet at the same time put these findings into perspective. Although children in stable shared residence overall did best, children who moved out of shared residence did equally well as children in stable sole residence. Being able to maintain relationships with both parents and having access to both parents' resources thus benefits children, but as soon as a shared residence is changed to another arrangement, this benefit seems to disappear.

Although the longitudinal, long-term design of this study constituted an improvement on earlier work, changes in child residence were assessed by means of retrospective questions. It may be difficult for parents to recall the child's main residence. Another reason why observed rates of instability may be biased is that not all respondents were followed for 10 years. If respondents experiencing high levels of instability were more likely to drop out, this may have led to an underestimation of the extent of instability. On the other hand, the divorces and separations in the sample took place in 2010, a year after a new law that stimulated (but not obliged) shared residence was introduced in the Netherlands. The introduction of this law led to a temporary peak in the first few years after it was introduced (Poortman and van Gaalen 2017), possibly leading to higher rates of instability among these parents. Selectivity issues may also have affected our findings regarding instability and child difficulties. Although general patterns were mostly unaffected, the estimates became smaller once control variables accounting for the (negative) selection of those experiencing instability were included. Given this clear sign of the role of selectivity, it cannot be ruled out that unobserved selectivity, for example, regarding health issues of the parents, may still account for our findings. Moreover, we recognize that response rates were not that high and that the NFN sample and panel attrition were selective. For instance, parents with higher socioeconomic status were more likely to participate and less likely to drop out. It is difficult to assess how such sample selectivity may have affected our results. In addition, changes in child residence were measured in greater detail (i.e., on a half-yearly basis) than changes in child

difficulties, which were measured at each wave (i.e., spanning several years between measures). Future research using a truly prospective design is needed to accurately capture causal relationships between instability and child well-being.

Note further that we relied on parent reports, and parents are often too optimistic about their children's well-being (Waters et al. 2003), which could lead to different associations when using child reports. Additionally, compared with parents who opted for mother or shared residence, the group with father residence was small. This resulted in even fewer cases when analyzing the specific types of change within this group. Small numbers may have limited the power of our analyses, warranting caution when interpreting the results. Lastly, we focused on the frequency and types of changes in child residence arrangements, emphasizing changes in the time spent in each parent's household. Cultures and families may, however, differ in how time spent in a family member's household relates to, for instance, discontinuity in other family relationships, as the fluidity of household boundaries varies across cultures and families. In addition, other factors might play a role. Besides children's preferences for changing main residence, the amount of resources available to parents to manage changes in child residence effectively, and child's ability to cope with these changes (e.g., personality) may influence whether instability leads to negative (or even positive) child outcomes. This variability in responses to instability could not be analyzed with the NFN data, but we encourage future research to explore this.

Theoretically, we were furthermore unable to directly test the instability perspective, which emphasizes the role of stress induced by change and related stressors. Unfortunately, the data do not include measures of stress. The role of specific stressors (e.g., loss of resources, changing neighborhoods) was also difficult to assess due to limited data. While our findings align with the instability perspective, we cannot say with certainty whether the greater difficulties among children experiencing instability are due to higher stress or which specific stressors are responsible. Future research would benefit from including repeated measures of child stress and specific stressors to more directly assess how changes in residence arrangements affect children's well-being.

From a policy perspective, our findings highlight the necessity of adopting a long-term perspective. Many countries, including the Netherlands, have introduced legal reforms to encourage shared parenting after divorce, typically focusing on arrangements made at the time of separation. Shared residence arrangements were, however, found to be relatively unstable, and particularly stable shared residence was beneficial for children. Therefore, more attention should be given to anticipating future changes and strategies to maintain stability. For example, legal professionals assisting divorcing parents could discuss with them how they might handle new partners or work-related changes, as such life-course changes often lead to alterations in the child's main residence (Poortman and van Gaalen 2017).

Despite these limitations, our study offered important insights. Over a 10-year period, instability in child residence arrangements increases and appears to be quite common. In

addition, our study was the first to show that changes in children's post-divorce residence arrangements may be harmful for children, especially in the case of sole-to-sole residence change. Our findings furthermore nuance the conclusion of prior research that shared residence is the most beneficial arrangement for children (Steinbach 2019). This is foremost the case when this arrangement remains unchanged after separation. However, given its high instability, with half of the children in shared residence experiencing a change, the presumed benefits of shared residence may be less in the longer run than often assumed.

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Supporting Information

Additional supporting information can be found online in the Supporting Information section.